

Threatened species

Human activities, such as habitat destruction and hunting, threaten many species of plants and animals with extinction.

In 1964, the International Union for the Conservation of Nature (IUCN)—the world authority on conservation—started to list endangered species on the Red List. Since then, it has grown to cover thousands of species.

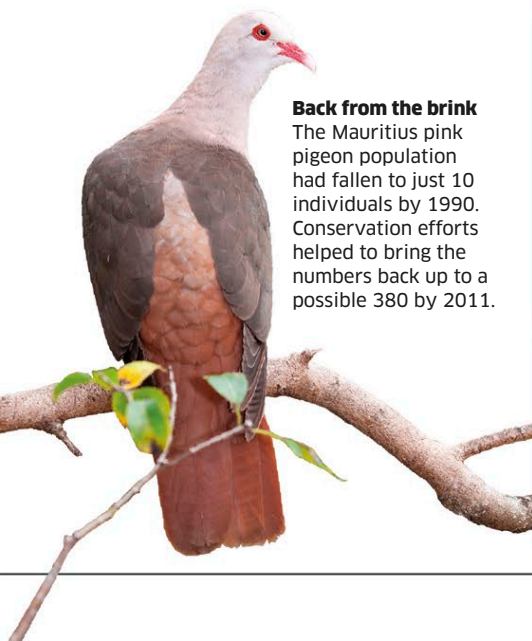
THE RED LIST CRITERIA

Scientists choose a level of threat for each species from among seven categories, depending on the results of surveys and other research. An eighth category includes species that need more study before a decision is made. The numbers of species on the Red List at the end of 2017 are listed below.

- Least concern: 30,385
- Near threatened: 5,445
- Vulnerable: 10,010
- Endangered: 7,507
- Critically endangered: 5,101
- Extinct in wild: 68
- Extinct: 844

Threatened numbers

The Red List has prioritized groups such as amphibians, reptiles, and birds that are thought to be at greatest risk. Most species—especially invertebrates, which make up 97 percent of all animal species—have not yet been assessed.



Back from the brink

The Mauritius pink pigeon population had fallen to just 10 individuals by 1990. Conservation efforts helped to bring the numbers back up to a possible 380 by 2011.

LEAST CONCERN

Widespread and abundant species facing no current extinction threat: some do well in habitats close to humans and have even been introduced into countries where they are not native.

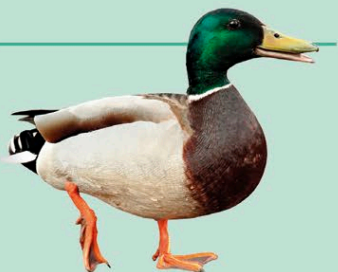


HUMAN

Homo sapiens

Location: Worldwide

Population: 7.5 billion; increasing



MALLARD

Anas platyrhynchos

Location: Worldwide

Population: 19 million; increasing



CANE TOAD

Rhinella marina

Location: Tropical America, introduced elsewhere

Population: Unknown; increasing

NEAR THREATENED

Species facing challenges that may make them threatened in the near future: a decreasing population size increases risk.



JAGUAR

Panthera onca

Location: Central and South America

Population: 64,000; decreasing



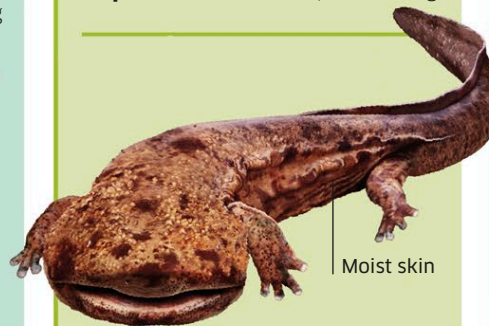
Shaggy, reddish feathers

REDDISH EGRET

Egretta rufescens

Location: Central and South America

Population: Unknown; decreasing



Moist skin

JAPANESE GIANT SALAMANDER

Andrias japonicus

Location: Japan

Population: Unknown; decreasing

PISTACHIO

Pistacia vera

Location: Southwestern Asia

Population: Unknown, decreasing



VULNERABLE

Species that may be spread over a wide range or abundant, but face habitat destruction and hunting.

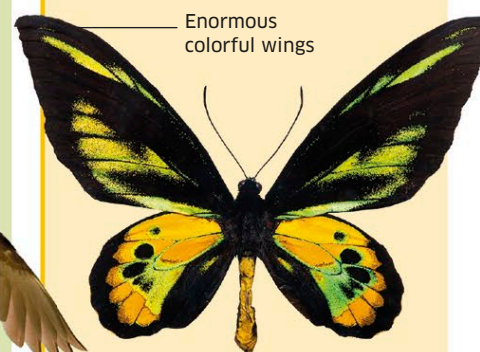
HUMBOLDT PENGUIN

Spheniscus humboldti

Location:

Western South America

Population: 30,000–40,000



Enormous colorful wings

ROTHSCHILD'S BIRDWING

Ornithoptera rothschildi

Location: Western New Guinea

Population: Unknown



GOLDEN HAMSTER

Mesocricetus auratus

Location: Syria, Turkey

Population: Unknown; decreasing



Long, paddle-like snout

AMERICAN PADDLEFISH

Polyodon spathula

Location: Mississippi River Basin

Population: More than 10,000